



Endangered tribe: Abdul Qadir embodied a spin-bowling art that Pakistan is struggling to revive. THE HINDU PHOTO LIBRARY

to play. You don't find form in international cricket. You go back to First-Class cricket and play regularly. And that is not just for yourself; it is for the country as well.

When you play as a youngster with the top players, you get better. You become a better player and develop a better understanding of the game.

I remember Greg Chappell once scored five zeros, one after another. Because of a tight schedule, he didn't have time to go back to First-Class cricket. He was playing top-class cricket against top bowlers all the time, and they didn't let him breathe.

He should have gone back to First-Class cricket.

Look at Virat Kohli. Such a great player, and he recently had to go back into First-Class cricket to find form. We have not done that. We have given central contracts to players without making First-Class cricket part of that responsibility.

A central contract is given to a player so that he keeps himself fit throughout the year and is available to play for Pakistan whenever required.

WHEN FAST BOWLERS GET NO HELP FROM THE PITCH, THEY MUST FIND OTHER WAYS TO DISMISS BATSMEN. THAT IS WHEN THEY START MANAGING THE BALL

That means playing First-Class cricket, playing club cricket and training throughout the year. That has not been the case in Pakistan.

The system keeps resetting itself

There is another problem: the way the board is run.

There is no consistent selection policy. People come in, bring their own people, change the format, change the First-Class structure and, six months, nine months or a year later, they are gone.